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LAY COUNSELOR
A C A D E M Y

Self-Paced

Curriculum & Learning Objectives

Module 1: Foundations of Lay Counseling

Module 1, Session 1

Introduction to The Lay Counselor Academy

Overview: In session one, we learn what lay counseling is and why we believe this non-academic pathway is necessary in our country. We will discuss the foundations of all mental health counseling, and the characteristics of the most effective counselors (with degrees or not!). We also review personal growth and its connection to providing high quality care to others.

Learning Objectives:

- Understand LCA foundations for safety, goodwill, support, equity, and empathy
- Understand why lay counseling is an important movement at this time in our country
- Enhance knowledge of the person-centered, strength-based philosophy of Lay Counseling
- Increase understanding about the connection between our personal growth and being an effective counselor

Module 1, Session 2

Equity Foundations: Identifying and Mitigating Negative Biases

Overview: In this session, we will learn about biases, stigma, and judgments, and the research demonstrating the significant negative impacts these have on health and wellbeing. We will affirm our professional responsibility as helpers to identify our own biases and judgments, and learn practices to extinguish, mitigate, and counter these.

Learning Objectives:

- Understand LCA foundations for safety, goodwill, support, equity, and empathy
- Understand the harm caused by negative bias, stigma and judgments
- Gain knowledge of the science and research on stigma and bias
- Increase ability to identify our own biases and judgments
- Learn practices to extinguish, mitigate and counter bias and judgments, to avoid harming others



Module 2: Core Counseling Approaches

Module 2, Session 1

Core Counseling Approaches

Overview: In session one, we will cover "Home Stance" strategies of warm body language and compassionate tone, open-ended questions, empathic reflection, affirming strengths, countering shame, and acknowledging feelings. These techniques are the foundational empathic communication we use in counseling. We will also explore "Ways of Being," the internal attitudes we cultivate to be maximally helpful to others.

Learning Objectives:

- Increase knowledge of the research base for "common factors," empathy, and the therapeutic alliance in mental healthcare
- Enhance understanding and knowledge of core empathic counseling strategies (Home Stance) and orientations (Ways of Being)
- Increase knowledge of the research on core counseling strategies and comfort and confidence in using these strategies.

Module 2, Session 2

Strength-Based, Values-Based Counseling

Overview: In this session, we will discuss the central importance of strength-based counseling perspectives. We will review the research base of strength-based approaches and why they are so effective as well as learn practical strategies to listen for, amplify, and enhance client strengths.

Learning Objectives:

- Increase knowledge of the research base of strength-based approaches and why they are so effective
- Learn practical strategies to 'strength-find' with clients and enhance comfort and confidence in identifying and amplifying client strengths



Module 3: Working with Thoughts, Helping with Depression & Anxiety

Module 3, Session 1

Working with Thoughts

Overview: We're diving into thoughts, thinking patterns, and how to be helpful! In this session, we'll gain knowledge and understanding of CBT-informed approaches, which we call "Working with Thoughts." We'll review practical strategies for eliciting and enhancing clients' "meta-cognition" and understand how to use a "Parts-of-Self" framework to help with thoughts that cause suffering.

Learning Objectives:

- Enhance understanding, knowledge and ability to use CBT-informed ("working with thoughts") approaches to help clients
- Understand how working-with-thoughts strategies can be a tool of oppression when misused and ensure the ability to avoid this
- Increase knowledge of common thoughts that cause suffering and how to elicit and enhance clients' meta-cognition
- Increase understanding and abilities in "parts-of-self" approaches to address thoughts that cause suffering

Module 3, Session 2

Helping with Depression and Anxiety

Overview: In this session, we'll discuss mental health conditions with the highest prevalence: anxiety and depression. We'll share the problem with the traditional diagnosis frameworks and why diagnosis isn't necessary for us to provide help. We'll review the signs and symptoms of anxiety & depression and learn how to decide which helping strategies will work best for clients, and recognizing and helping with "second-arrow" suffering.

Learning Objectives:

- Understand the problems, drawbacks, and largely unnecessary nature of diagnosis
- Identify signs and symptoms of anxiety and depression
- Learn the importance of following a client's preferences, experiences, and strengths to find what will be helpful for them and open-ended questions to elicit these
- Increase ability to recognize "second arrow" suffering in clients and utilize strategies to help
- Learn more evidenced-based strategies to help clients address depressive and anxious symptoms



Module 4: Positive Psychology, Happiness Practices & Staying on Fertile Ground

Module 4, Session 1

Positive Psychology and Happiness Practices

Overview: Let's deepen our strengths-based approaches! In this session we will discuss the philosophy and principles of positive psychology and the research on positive emotions. We'll learn evidence-based happiness practices, how to help clients enhance wellbeing through increasing positive emotions and experiences, and avoiding "toxic positivity" and other missteps.

Learning Objectives:

- Increase knowledge of the research base of positive psychology, including evidence supporting the impact of positive emotions on well-being
- Understand the limitations of problem-focused and symptom-reduction-only approaches in counseling
- Gain knowledge of effective positive psychology techniques to foster resilience and happiness in clients
- Increase awareness and ability to avoid "toxic positivity" or minimizing clients' challenges when using positive psychology strategies

Module 4, Session 2

Staying on Fertile Ground and Avoiding Anti-Growth Practices

Overview: When counseling is effective, it feels different from typical, interpersonal interactions. The quality of the interactions is deeper, more emotional, and self-reflective. We call it "Fertile Ground." In this session, we'll learn to recognize when clients are on (and off) Fertile Ground, how to guide them to Fertile Ground, and how to help them stay in this place of self-reflection, change, and growth. We'll review anti-growth missteps, what might make us vulnerable to these, and how to repair when necessary.

Learning Objectives:

- Increase ability to identify when clients are on Fertile Ground
- Enhance confidence in using strategies to help people stay on Fertile Ground
- Understand the importance of avoiding advice and other anti-growth practices
- Increase comfort and confidence in avoiding missteps and engaging in repair with clients when missteps happen



Module 5: Motivational Interviewing, Helping with Addictive Disorders & Difficult Childhoods

Module 5, Session 1

Addictive Disorders and Motivational Interviewing

Overview: In this session, we'll take a deep dive into substance use and other addictive disorders. We'll cover the historical divide of addiction treatment from mental health, the impact of stigma on those who struggle with addictive disorders, and identifying and countering any addiction-related judgments we might have. We'll also discuss one of the most effective, evidenced-based helping strategies for addictive disorders: Motivational Interviewing.

Learning Objectives:

- Identify our own judgments, conditioning, and experiences around addictive disorders and practices to counter them when doing so would be helpful
- Learn the symptoms of addictive disorders and debunk common myths
- Understand the core philosophy and practices of Motivational Interviewing (MI)

Module 5, Session 2

Helping People with Adverse Childhood Experiences & Managing Distress Empathy and Preventing Vicarious Trauma

Overview: In this session we'll gain a thorough knowledge of adverse childhood experiences, the impact these experiences have in adulthood, and how we can be helpful as counselors when people share with us about difficulties in childhood. We'll learn about distress empathy, its risks, and strategies for recognizing and mitigating it in ourselves.

Learning Objectives:

- Gain knowledge about adverse childhood experiences, trauma, and toxic stress
- Understand the foundations of Home Stance and Ways of Being in trauma-informed counseling
- Recognize distress empathy and enhance our ability to prevent vicarious trauma



Module 6: Suicidal Ideation, Mandated Reporting & Personal Identities in Counseling

Module 6, Session 1

Suicidal Thoughts and How to Help

Overview: Suicide and thoughts of suicide have been addressed in the mental health field, historically, in ways that cause rupture and harm to those seeking help. In this session, we cover these harms, how to avoid them, and strategies for responding that preserve or strengthen the therapeutic alliance. Thoughts of suicide are incredibly common and, often, are very rich areas of exploration. We have an opportunity to increase our self-awareness around this topic and to practice non-judgment, mindful presence, and a deep curiosity to increase our ability to be helpful.

Learning Objectives:

- Enhance understanding of risk and protective factors in suicidal thoughts and actions
- Increase knowledge and skill in evidenced-based strategies to help clients with suicidal thoughts
- Increase comfort and confidence in helping clients who have suicidal thoughts

Module 6, Session 2

Personal Identities in Counseling

Overview: In this session, we will be focused on how we can remain open to hearing about people's experiences related to their identities. In particular, remaining in a helpful stance as we invite, listen to, and reflect clients' experiences of discrimination, marginalization, systemic oppression, bias, and other difficulties relating to aspects of their identities. We'll also cover practices to increase our own awareness and comfort with exploring other's struggles and strengths around these topics.

Learning Objectives:

- Increase awareness and understanding of counselor's historical and sociocultural literacy
- Expand capacity to empathize and normalize patients' experiences with positive cultural identity experiences as well as experiences of racism and other discrimination
- Enhance confidence and skill in talking about identities in the counseling relationship



Module 7: Boundaries and Continual Learning, Endings

Module 7, Session 1

Boundaries, Humility, Continued Learning and Growth

Overview: Boundaries are a big part of all of our lives! For many of us, knowing our boundaries and being able to set limits is a lifelong endeavor. This is true for our clients as well! In this session, we'll discuss how our history and personality shape our own boundary tendencies, ethical considerations in boundaries with clients, how to make decisions about self-disclosure, and how to repair when we have misstepped with a client. We will review the profound importance of humility as counselors and the dangers of arrogance.

Learning Objectives:

- Enhance understanding of the complexity of boundaries in the counseling relationship
- Deepen knowledge of how to make decisions about self-disclosures
- Ensure commitment to regular clinical support when engaged in counseling
- Increase knowledge of a growth-mindset and humility and the relationship to effective helping

Module 7, Session 2

Ending Counseling Relationships

Overview: Endings are happening all the time: seasons change, our kids grow, we leave jobs, we finish a book we loved, friendships end, we experience death. Counseling relationships end, too. By enhancing our awareness of our tendencies and histories with endings, we become more comfortable and confident in approaching endings with clients, and we enhance how helpful we can be with when counseling with clients ends.

